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STREET SMARTS



What my father taught me in 1,109 texts

BY MK PARRISH · \$18

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For my father. I had to love you to lose you, and I would do it again, every single time.

01

BOOK SMART

The last real question my father ever asks me is a riddle, and like all his riddles, he already knows the answer.

MK, he says, *why are you so book smart, but not street smart at all?*

I am on the phone in the dark, which is where I am for most of the important things in my life, and I laugh, because he is teasing me, and because it is true, and because being seen that clearly by someone who loves you is its own kind of vertigo. *I don't know, Dad,* I tell him. *Mom kept me in a world of butterflies and unicorns, and then released my carcass into a world of hyenas and rhinos.*

He laughs. He has a great laugh, my father. Bold and bald and entirely his own. He texts the way he talks, which is one of the ten thousand things I love about him and could not have told you I loved until I had only the texts left. No masks. No ulterior motives. No false promises or insincere smiles. He is one of the rare people in this world who simply *are.*

We talk for four hours that night. It is four in the morning my time when I finally hang up, and I sit there in the dark afterward with the strangest, warmest thought arriving fully formed in my chest, like something set down gently by a hand I cannot see. *I actually have a father who loves me.* He tells me, that night, that it is a happy Father's Day because of me. He is always doing that, making me feel special and empowered and, his word, *strong.* I have so few memories of him from when I was small. That night becomes one I will keep forever, because it turns out to be the last.

I do not know yet that I am talking to my father for the last time. I think we are at the beginning of something. I think we have all the time in the account and we are finally going to spend it.

I HAD TO LOVE YOU TO LOSE YOU

My phone rings on the fourteenth of April.

My father has had a massive heart attack. He is brain dead. There is a sentence you can write a hundred times and it never once starts to mean anything, and that is the sentence.

He is the reason I am about to move across the country. He and I have the strongest connection I have ever had to another living person, and we built the whole of it out of text messages and a few phone calls, across twenty-five years and a continent, without ever once being in the same room as adults. People love to say there has to be a reason for it. They say it the way you hum to fill a silence. I do not have a reason. I have only the thing itself, which is that I had finally, at long last, after a quarter century of him being a rumor on the far brown edge of the map of my life, gotten a father. And then, eleven months later, I lost him.

I had to love you to lose you. That is the whole brutal arithmetic of it. If I had kept him at the distance the years had set for us, his death would have been a fact, the way the deaths of distant relatives are facts. Instead I had opened the door. I had let him all the way in. And so when he went, he took a piece of the wall with him, and the wind has been coming through that gap ever since.

THE 1,109 TEXTS

After he dies, I begin to read.

One thousand, one hundred and nine text messages. Four hundred and two messages on Facebook. Four emails. And eight seconds of the only voicemail I ever saved of his voice. I read each line the way you read a letter from someone who loves you and has been gone a long time. Slowly. Twice. Out loud, sometimes, just to put his words back into the air of a room.

And here is what undoes me. He did not give himself enough credit. He was so intelligent, so funny, so unbearably, blindingly alive that being near him would have required sunglasses, and I can hear him now, teasing me about mine, that rare and easy banter we somehow had from the very first exchange. He spoke his truth, gave the advice, and moved on. He lived for his purpose, which he told me, that last night, was his children.

What I did not tell him, what I will spend a long time wishing I had said, is that he was my purpose too. That he made me see the light in my own endless dark. That he had handed me, casually, in a text message, between a joke and a riddle, the one thing I had been starving for my entire life without knowing its name. Unconditional love. Love with no hidden motive and no desire to control me and a true, baffling faith in my abilities, even on the days I had none in myself. He even said he was crazy for it sometimes. He filled a hole in my heart, and the wild part, the part I keep returning to, is that he wrote to me once and said that I had filled one in his.

UNCONDITIONAL LOVE

I keep his texts the way other people keep scripture. Here are some of the things my father said to me. I have changed almost nothing. They were perfect already.

Once your eyes have been opened, it is hard to put the blinders back on.

You need to be you. That is all. Not a sister. Not a daughter. Not an aunt. Just you.

You just have to breathe.

You deserve to be heard.

Speak your mind, and he can either accept it or not. That is up to him.

You do not need to explain why or how you feel. It is the way you feel and nothing more.

It is good to know you are safe.

I will not lie to you. I am not afraid of you knowing the truth.

There are people sitting and waiting to be there for you, for no reason other than to see you safe and well and to see you get what you want.

I care. I care that you are out from under any stress.

You have been controlled, and now you are not. They liked it when you were.

You got this. Just breathe.

You are not alone.

I love you.

He signs off, more than once, with the same line, in all capitals, the way you would shout something across a distance so it carries. *YOU ARE NOT ALONE.* I did not believe him at the time. I am only now, slowly, learning to.

HAVING A SMOKE ON FLATBUSH

So I talk to him.

I know how it sounds. I talk to my father on Flatbush Avenue, the Brooklyn street where he was born, where the old Dime Savings Bank stands like a temple to a city that does not exist anymore. I have a coffee and an imaginary cigarette, our morning ritual, except I am the only one holding anything. And I tell him things, and then, because I have always been good at this, I make up his answers.

It is exactly the way it always was, I realize, and the realizing makes me laugh and ache at the same time. When I was small and he was already gone, I used to make up the endings to the bedtime stories he was not there to finish. Now I make up his responses to my grief. The medium has not changed. Only the direction.

He used to tell me that things are only worth the value you put on them. I fought him on that one, hard, the way you fight the truths that are about to cost you something. And then his mother sells his signed memorabilia after he dies, and it does not fetch much, a few packs of New York cigarettes' worth, and I sit on Flatbush and I finally, finally understand what he meant, and I can feel him laughing at me getting it at last. The man could not write the signs any clearer if he hired a skywriter.

I feel him most at moments exactly like this one, when I am not looking for him, when I just start typing and look up to find I have written eight hundred words about feelings and some other stupid stuff. I have a man in the moon now. He lives in the darkness inside me until I am ready to sparkle. That last night, he gave me a parent's most important and final gift. He told me that death was not something to be afraid of, and he told

me to live my purpose. I did not know it then, but those four hours were the prelude to everything I have written since. They were the prelude to this.

THE CAGE WITH THE CURTAINS DRAWN

I have to tell you about the years after, because Street Smarts is not a story about a man who taught me from a safe distance. It is a story about what his lessons cost, and what they saved.

After he died, I came apart. I want to say that plainly, without dressing it up, because somebody reading this is coming apart right now and deserves to know they are not the only one. There was a year, more than a year, that I do not recommend to anyone. I lived in apartments with the curtains drawn against views other people would have killed for. I learned to be afraid of being alive, which is a strange and specific terror, the fear of the beautiful view, the fear of looking inward and counting blessings I was sure I no longer deserved. I chased numbness in every form it is sold in, and I am not going to glamorize a single one of them, because there is nothing in that country but a deeper version of the dark.

People had names for me in those years. Cruel ones, public ones, the kind that get typed with hashtags by men who feel large only when they are making a woman feel small. I will not give them the dignity of their names in my book. I will only say that I learned, the hardest possible way, the difference between the people who throw the stones and the people who help you build the new foundation. For a long time I made the fool's mistake of hoping the stone-throwers would do both. I had this unwavering, embarrassing faith that the very souls who whittled me down to a stump would pick up those same stones and help me build. I believed they wanted to put me back together. They did not. That is not a tragedy anymore. It is just information. It is, as my father would say, street smarts.

And underneath all of it, the whole time, was the thing I could not say out loud to a single living person. I sat in the dark and I told my mother, in a text I am not proud of, that I would not survive the night without her. She

told me she would send an ambulance. She never did. I lived anyway. I want to be very careful here, because if you are where I was: please do not do it the way I did, alone in the dark betting your life on a text message. Pick up the phone. Call 988. Tell a real human being out loud. I survived the cage with the curtains drawn, and the only reason I can write this from the other side of it is that some stubborn speck of gold in me refused to go out. I need you to keep yours lit.

There was one more loss folded inside the others, quieter, and somehow it cut the deepest of all.

Ju Ju was the only grandmother I ever truly had. The calls with her, near the end, were the ones that finished the breaking. She would call me by the wrong name and not notice. She would list the things she cherished about her life and I would wait, the whole call, to hear myself somewhere in the list, and I would not be there. I told someone, around then, that the way I felt about Ju Ju by the end was the same way I had come to feel about so much of the love I was raised to believe in. Not absent, exactly. Just inauthentic in a way that stung the soul, like a hug from someone already looking over your shoulder for the exit.

I say this not to indict her. She was old, and tired, and the mind goes where it goes. I say it because grief is not always a clean death. Sometimes it is the slow discovery that a love you were counting on to hold you was never built to bear weight. And learning the difference, learning which loves are load-bearing and which are decorative, is the entire and brutal curriculum of becoming street smart.

LIVE, DON'T MERELY EXIST

I cannot tell you how many years I wasted merely existing. That is how old I am, my father would joke. But here is the truth underneath the joke. For a long time I confused being alive with being safe, and being safe with being numb, and I built a whole life out of the not-feeling, and called it peace, and starved inside it.

Existing is not a feeling. It is the absence of one. And one night, staring at the Empire State Building the way I did every night, I looked over and it was me on the ledge, falling, free-falling, and I understood that I had a choice I had been pretending I did not have. I could keep merely existing, a sleepwalker in a beautiful apartment with the curtains drawn. Or I could live.

So I make myself a promise, and I always keep mine. Someday my light will shine, and not because someone handed it to me as the pretense for some property offer or some quiet bid for control. No. I will make my own light. I will let it burn the grief I carry daily for the love and the life I once knew. I will never again dim someone else's light to make my own look brighter, and I will never offer a flashlight to someone and then bill them for the batteries. I will ask the people whose lights are made of the same stuff as mine, love and truth, to help me light up skies that have stayed dark for far too long. And I will use the fire to burn, finally, every last way I clung to the belief that the people who hurt me would ever be the ones to heal me.

I am the only one who can heal my brokenness. I pick myself up piece by piece. I am in control of whom I allow to hurt me, exactly as much as they once controlled the love they doled out to me. That is not bitterness. By the end, it is something closer to freedom.

STREET SMART

So here we are, Dad.

I am street smart now. I got there the way you said I would, which is to say the hard way, the only way it ever takes. I can read a room now before anyone in it has spoken. I know the difference between a person who is and a person who performs. I know which loves are load-bearing. I learned to breathe, the way you told me to, over and over, in all caps, when I could not. *You just have to breathe.* I am breathing.

You completed a parent's most important task before you left. You taught me that death is not the thing to be afraid of. The thing to be afraid of is a life spent merely existing, with the curtains drawn against your own one wild view. You gave me a purpose in a text message at four in the morning, and I did not understand it at the time, and I understand it now. *You got a great story, kid. You just need to tell it.*

I am telling it. You are holding it.

I had to love you to lose you. And given the choice, knowing the cost, knowing the years in the cage and the names and the dark, I would open that door and let you in again every single time. Because a quarter of a century of you being a rumor taught me how to survive. But eleven months of you being my father taught me, at last, how to live.

To be continued. Which, I have learned, is just another way of saying: I am still here.

A note, from me to you. If any of these pages found you in the dark, please do not stay there alone the way I did. In the United States you can call or text 988 any hour of any day and reach a real human being who wants you to stay. Your light is worth keeping lit. I promise. And I always keep mine.

♡ MK

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